

Reactance

What is it?

People resist when they feel their freedom to choose is being taken away.

History

Introduced by psychologist Jack Brehm in **1966**, showing that people push back when they sense pressure, control, or forced direction.

The Psychology Behind It

When people feel restricted, their brain tries to restore freedom by doing the opposite. The harder you try to force an action, the more people resist, disengage, or avoid it.

Why It Matters

- Lower engagement
- Reduced conversions
- Higher frustration
- Negative product experience
- More drop-offs

How to Apply It

- Provide choices (not single forced paths)
- Use positive framing that highlights benefits
- Avoid aggressive persuasion tactics
- Be honest + transparent with intent
- Let users stay in control of how they interact

Theory in Action

CrazyEgg offers multiple pricing tiers so users don't feel forced into only one option.
Supermarkets with self-checkout give freedom over pace + decisions, reducing pressure.

Final Thought

Good design guides — it doesn't force. When users feel respected and in control, they choose easier, trust more, and stay longer.